difficult to stand up straight. Every movement was hurting and every shot increased the pain. I soon realized that all-out attack was my only option. Unable to bear the pain any longer, I tried to hit a Saqlain doosra – the off-spinner's delivery that goes the other way from normal after pitching, a ball that Saqlain was the first to master – over mid off for another boundary. The ball bounced more than expected and I ended up top-edging the ball. I could see Wasim getting under the ball at mid off and was praying for him to drop the catch. But I was out for 136 and was devastated.

It was a painful walk back to the pavilion. Even the standing ovation from the crowd did little to alleviate the pain at not having finished the match. However, I must say that I really did not expect us to lose the match from there, with just 17 runs to get and three wickets, including Srinath and Kumble, still left. In fact, I couldn't believe what was happening when we were bowled out for 258 and lost by 12 runs. My world seemed to collapse around me and I just couldn't hold back the tears in the dressing room. My back was in horrible shape and mentally I was at a serious low.

It was the only time in my life when I didn't go out to receive the Man of the Match award. Raj Singh Dungarpur tried to persuade me but I said to him that I was in no state, physically or mentally, to leave the dressing room. He understood and left me to myself. Even when we were leaving for Delhi the next morning, I couldn't even carry my hand luggage. It was as if someone was sticking needles into my back all the time and I couldn't sit in one position for more than two or three minutes.

In hindsight, I should not have played the Delhi and Kolkata Test matches that followed, but my urge to play against Pakistan drove me on. I had told the BCCI all about my physical condition and they had left it up to me whether to play or not and at the time I felt I would be able push myself.

The second Test, starting in Delhi on 4 February 1999, was very much Anil Kumble's match and it was his world-record spell of 10–74 in the second innings that helped us level the series. Anil has won many Test matches for India and he was unplayable at the Kotla in Delhi, as he became only the second bowler in the history of Test cricket, after Jim Laker in 1956, to pick up all ten wickets in an innings. In Pakistan's second innings I handed Anil's sweater and cap to umpire Arani Jayaprakash before every over he bowled. It worked well for us and